Introduction to Leadership Competency

Leadership is one of the three competencies of the Honors Program. By completing the program, students will utilize personal leadership values and strengths in a team environment toward a common goal. Before we can begin to learn that, it is important for us to dispel a few myths that you might have heard about leadership:

Myth #1: All leaders have the same characteristics.

Every individual has a unique set of strengths and weaknesses, of likes and dislikes, of passions and interests. There is not a single "correct" way to be a leader. There is not a perfect set of characteristics that a leader must have to be effective. Instead, being an effective leader requires each person to become more self-aware and reflective about their individual attributes and to utilize those attributes in a positive manner.

Myth #2: The only people who are leaders are the ones with positions.

When we initially think of someone in a leadership position, we envision a "sage on the stage" persona. We picture a single individual in front of a crowd of followers who are looking to that person for guidance. Cultural images might be presidents, monarchs, or worship leaders. However, a leader can also be a "guide on the side." This might be a teacher, a coach, or a parental figure in your life. It is someone who provides you with advice, guidance, knowledge, and skills in order to help you make a decision for yourself. Neither the "sage on the stage" nor the "guide on the side" is more or less powerful than the other; rather, they are simply two different styles of leadership.

Myth #3: Leadership is only for loud, extroverted people.

Similar to the previous myth, we typically think of leaders as those who are shouting in front of a crowd. However, consider individuals who are historic leaders with quieter personae (e.g. Rosa Parks, Mother Teresa, Barack Obama). You can probably think of quiet leaders from your own life. Perhaps you had a teacher, coach, religious leader, or mentor who greatly impacted you but did not have a loud personality. Consider what characteristics of leadership made these individuals effective.

What is leadership?

How might we begin to define leadership? Is there one definition of leadership, or does it depend on the individual? Is leadership always the same or might it change and adapt, based on time and context? These are important questions to consider.

Northouse (2013) notes that until the mid-20th century, leadership was considered to be a *trait* that only great people were fortunate to have upon birth. Traits are things like height, personality, eye color, etc. Either you have a trait or you don't. Either you're born a leader or you're not.

In the 20th century, there was a shift to consider leadership as a *skill* that people can develop over time (Northouse, 2013). Skills are competencies that people can learn to develop. In this sense, leadership might be available to everyone. It is a studied and learned skill.

Because behavior is not a solitary act, there is an inherent *relational* component to it. We cannot be a leader if we do not have a team of followers. If people don't "buy in" to our vision, so to

speak, we cannot accomplish anything.

Given all of that, how might you define leadership? Write your definition here and we can talk about it in class.
My definition of leadership is an individual who guide and direct people in some form or way.

Leadership Styles
Each individual subscribes to a philosophy of leadership. Certainly, your unique life experiences and the context in which you are working may cause you to alter how you employ this philosophy, but, for the most part, your philosophy of leadership stays the same. According to White and Lippit (1960), there are three primary philosophies of leadership: authoritarian, democratic, and laissez-faire (White and Lippit, 1960).
Authoritarian leaders believe that most people dislike work and they need to be directed and controlled. These are the micro-managers of the world. They believe that individuals thrive on reward and punishment. Authoritarian leadership can be helpful in providing structure, setting and achieving goals, and increasing efficiency and productivity. Negative outcomes might be that authoritarian leaders do not take the time to establish relationships with individuals, which can cause problems on long-term projects.
Can you think of examples of authoritarian leaders? Or, can you think of examples where authoritarian leadership might be useful?
I feel like a good example of an authoritarian leader is our parents. Without them guiding us and setting up a structure of living for us to follow. I do think it is a less extreme example but there are defenitally authoritarian qualities in parenting.

Democratic leaders believe that people enjoy work and are self-motivated. When people are empowered, they accept and seek responsibility. These individuals do not try to control workers, but they might define work requirements for them. They might work with people to help them find their passions or ways to utilize their strengths. Democratic leadership often works well in teams when communication is key. Benefits of this leadership style include an increased satisfaction among workers and a greater commitment to a group goal. Negative outcomes include a lack of efficiency due to the time required in order to employ this leadership style.
Can you think of examples of democratic leaders? Or, can you think of examples where democratic leadership might be useful?
I think a democratic leader is very useful in group projects. When someone has a voice, but takes ideas from the good of the whole group, it can benefit the collective in many ways

Laissez-faire leaders take a “hands-off, let-things-ride” approach (Northouse, 2013, p. 174). Traditionally, laissez-faire leadership has been described as absence of leadership where leaders ignore workers and their motivations. However, recent research argues that this style of leadership may an intentional and strategic choice of the leader to “acknowledge and defer to

followers' abilities, decrease their dependency, and increase their self-determination, self-competence, and autonomy" (Northouse, 2013, p. 174). This approach seeks to empower followers to lead.

Can you think of examples of laissez-faire leaders? Or, can you think of examples where laissez-faire leadership might be useful?

A good example of a Steve Jobs. Steve Jobs would do this to help encourage creativity as well as help his team develop better through this way.

Growing in the Competency

Now that you have a sense of what leadership might mean and some examples of leaders, let's examine how the honors program seeks to help you grow in this area. Our focus within this competency is on two components: values and teams.

Values

The values category is all about you and how you might utilize your personal leadership values and strengths as members of campus and community organizations – and, ultimately, as professionals. As part of your leadership development experience, you will identify and reflect on your values, strengths, and weaknesses. You'll begin this process within HONR 201, but we also hope you'll find other situations on campus and in the world that allow you to do this.

Once you have reflected on your own values and strengths, we ask you to critique other individuals within group contexts. If you're working on a class project, trying to achieve a goal in a campus organization, or working on a team in your off-campus job, what models or styles – either from the list above or others that you'll be exposed to – work well and what doesn't work well?

Finally, as part of your leadership application experience, we ask you to apply your own personal theory and values of leadership within an organization. Given that you know your own strengths and values and you've had the opportunity to observe and critique others, you should be able to apply something that works in a group.

Teams

The teams component is all about how you work with other people. Granted, there is some overlap between values and teams because, again, we can't be a leader without followers or team members. As part of your leadership development experience, you will identify various types of roles within group or team settings. In organizations, projects, job situations, etc. consider the different roles that people assume based on their own leadership strengths or values. Once you identify them, it is necessary to reflect on them. What combination of roles might be effective or not effective based on the ultimate goal?

Once you have identified and reflected on roles within groups, we ask you to apply this learning by practicing them in your leadership application experience. Work with other individuals to accomplish a goal and then reflect on what went well and what you might change in the future. After you do this, you should be able to articulate your own philosophy of leadership that will guide you in your future collaboration with others as a professional.

So What?

Why is leadership such a big deal? Everyone has a different answer to this question. We want you to start formulating yours below. Why do you think we spend time developing your leadership skills in honors? What purpose do you think it might serve? Jot down some ideas.

Leadership is a big deal for many reasons. I feel like the biggest reason leaders are able to provide direction for a group. Leaders are able to help people understand things and keep people on track. Leaders are also able to help a group of people with decision making as well as being a voice for the group. I think the biggest part of leadership is providing a sense of direction. I think in honors we spend so much time working on developing leadership skills in honors is because this can help us in almost every area in our lives and help us be better people. It can help us in our work lives with a collective of people, help us be a better parent at home, as well as almost any other area of life. This is a big characteristics of life and can help in many directions of life.

References

Northouse, P. (2013). *Leadership: Theory and practice* (6th ed.). Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications, Inc.

White, R. K. & Lippitt, R. (1960). *Autocracy and democracy: An experimental inquiry*. New York: Harper & Bros.